

NOW BANKING ON INDIANS

Democratic front-runners Hillary and Obama battle for the support of Indian-Americans as the community emerges as a big fundraiser

■ By Lavina Melwani in New York

The mating dance is about to begin. As the presidential elections of 2008 loom ever closer, the ritual of picking one's favourite candidate has begun in the Indian-American community. Last week, the New York Sheraton Hotel was turned into a piece of India as 1,230 affluent Indian-Americans—many with spouses and grown children in tow—turned up for a high-octane dinner for Senator Hillary Rodham Clinton's campaign hosted by the Indian Americans for Hillary 2008 (IAFH), which has been initiated by hotelier Sant Singh Chatwal and a group of prominent business leaders.

The evening raised close to \$2.5 million (about Rs 10 crore) and the cheques are still coming in. Tickets were \$1,000 (Rs 40,000) per person for the gala dinner and many of the VIP donors gave the maximum allowed under campaign finance law—\$4,600 (Rs 1.84 lakh) per person or \$9,200 a couple, for the opportunity to rub shoulders with the power people and more importantly, a chance to have a photo-op with Hillary. Chatwal had spared no effort in inviting the big players from India, including S.P. Hinduja, Subhash Chandra of Zee, Naresh Goyal of Jet Airways and Venugopal Dhoot of Videocon. Civil Aviation Minister Praful Patel was present at the hotel but he did not attend either the fundraising dinner or the private reception with Hillary.

Indian nationals cannot contribute to American candidates,

so why were so many movers and shakers there? "My feeling is it's always good to have successful friends around because we Indian-Americans like meeting powerful people," says Chatwal, adding that many of the big names already have a foot in the US with their business ventures.

Besides US political figures, the *desi* power people who are US citizens were there in full force to support the candidate. The co-chairs of the event included Mukesh 'Mike' Patel of Asian American Hotel Owners Association (AAHOA), MacKay Shields CEO Ravi Akhoury, wellness guru Deepak Chopra and Dr Bhupi Patel. There were also enough big-name physicians to cure any ailment you might have had. There was wild applause in the crowded ballroom when Hillary, dressed in a canary yellow suit, appeared on the podium. That she and her husband, former president Bill Clinton, have a huge reservoir of goodwill with Indian-Americans is common knowledge.

So where does Senator Barack Obama fit into the picture? The charismatic Obama has been on a roll, but the brouhaha over the leaked memo from his camp that termed Hillary as the 'Senator D Punjab' has set him back

The dinner with Hillary raised about \$2.5 m and cheques are still coming in. Many gave the maximum allowed under law.

among some in the Indian community. He apologised for the goof-up saying, "The memo's caustic tone and its focus on contributions by Indian-Americans to the Clinton campaign was potentially hurtful, and as such, unacceptable. The memo also ignored my own long-standing relationship to—and

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support from—the Indian-American community."

At cocktails and chat rooms, in gatherings and at work, the Indian-American community has been venting about the Senator's remarks. Ask Chatwal whether the flap over Obama has helped or hindered Hillary and he says, "I think it has helped more because it brought Indian-Americans closer together. Majority are for Hillary Clinton." He makes it a point to mention that Bill Clinton was the first president to visit India since Jimmy Carter's visit in 1977 and the Clintons have really